

*City Lights Emblaze Village Fishing Grounds: The Re-Imaginings of Waterscape by Lake Malawi Fishers**

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This article describes the remaking of fishing practices by the Lakeside Tonga fishers of Malawi, in relation to the local and regional redistribution of power since the colonial era. It first reviews the centrality of the regional waterscape in shaping interventions that eventually turned Lake Malawi's western shore into a reserve for long-distance migrant labour. Previous reports have tended to treat the resultant 'returned labour migrants' as advocates of the commercialisation of fishery. Bringing new types of gear, they are said to have introduced technical and organisational innovations, most notably urban labour relations, into the local fishery. The outcomes have been represented as an irreversible destruction of the indigenous modes of fishing. Such teleological representations disregard any continuity in tenure regimes on the lake, and have been used to justify various reforms, including 'co-management' with the government and international development agencies in the postcolonial era. The article challenges the view that indigenous fishing practices in Malawi have been destroyed by returning male migrants interested only in commercialisation, by revealing the agency of Malawian fishers in remaking fishery practices and institutions. The Lakeside Tonga fishers do indeed form fishing units that resemble urban labour relations. However, I argue that their practice is not a disruptive break but an artful recombination of previously known techniques and organisations, which they represent and realise through urban-related terms. This transformation was not a passive, irreversible dislocation or dismemberment of fishing and its economy from the village context. Instead, it is an active progress in which fishers appropriate and project models onto the lake, creating a multi-layered waterscape on which they manoeuvre distances relative to different loci of power.

Introduction

Lake Malawi (Nyasa, Nyassa, Niassa) is a long, narrow body of water forming the southernmost of the Rift lakes, with its outlet flowing into the Zambezi via the Shire River. The lake and its surrounding escarpments have played a formative role in the history of the area, constricting human passage to the advantage of those with command over the water.¹

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1 S. Agnew, 'Environment and History: the Malawian Setting', in B. Pachai (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi* (London, Longman, 1972), pp. 28–48.

Practices and representations of lake use, in the past and present, have been central to the creation and reproduction of personal and group identities, as is apparent in historical narratives of various groups that have emerged on the lake's shore area. Despite the lake's apparent marginality in the political economy of the region, the ways in which its shores connect to the wider world have had profound impacts on both ends of the connection,² and it continues to be a target of much intervention and reinvention.³ The trade route connecting the interior of Africa to the Indian Ocean and bearing slave traffic ran across pre-colonial Lake Malawi. With British colonial rule came a redirection of the flow of persons and goods, at first in response to an anti-slavery campaign led by missionaries. Building the Nyasaland Protectorate cut the old trade route across the lake, and redirected persons and goods towards the colonial urban centres of southern Africa. Indeed, the development of the region itself owes much to the manipulation of lakeside territorial borders and the creation of a labour reserve around the western and southern shores.

Lakes and other freshwaters have long been targets for European exploration, conquest and re-invention in Africa. During the nineteenth century, when the British began to penetrate the interior of what they had called the dark continent, its waters provided the sole means of mass and long distance transport. However, prospective European settlers often found the waterfronts unattractive because of the high occurrence of tropical diseases. Colonial cities were constructed mainly in the highlands far away from the wetlands.⁴ In the making of colonial states, major bodies of water have been designated as 'natural' state boundaries. The management of the traffic in people and goods across these waters, and the justification of interventions to reinvent the traffic, were crucial processes in the formation of colonial states and their economy.

The case of Lake Malawi, the focus of this article, illustrates this point. The current terrestrial boundaries of Malawi seem 'natural' compared to its neighbouring states. The country's territory roughly corresponds to the western half of the lake's watershed and the trough of lowland carrying its outlet to the Zambezi. That the construction of this state and its current political economy was based on a particular interpretation of the waterscape has been acknowledged only in the immediate post colony.⁵

Throughout much of the colonial and postcolonial periods, most of Lake Malawi's men spent much of their lives away from home, migrating back and forth between town and country. When returned labour migrants resettled at home, they brought capital and urban experience, and contributed to the technical and organisational remaking of fishery practices. The literature on Malawi captures the economics of this transformation, but little attention is given to transformation as a culturally imagined process. This article describes the ongoing process in which residents of the lake's western shore, in particular the Lakeside Tonga fishers, re-imagine their land and waterscapes in partial response to change on a macro scale. It focuses primarily on the ways in which urban metaphors are deployed in the newer aspects of fishery in order to distinguish them from the pre-existing regime. This transformation is not viewed as a passive, irreversible disembedding of fishery and its economy from the village context.

2 This is not to say that the impact was symmetrical in scale.

3 The most recent being the Mtwara Development Corridor, which happens to be the reactivation of the westward trade route.

4 P. Curtin, 'Medical Knowledge and Urban Planning in Colonial Tropical Africa', in S. Feierman and J. Janzen (eds), *The Social Basis of Health and Healing in Africa* (Berkeley, Los Angeles, Oxford, University of California Press, 1992), pp. 235–55. O. Goerg, 'From Hill Station (Freetown) to Downtown Conakry (First Ward): Comparing French and British Approaches to Segregation in Colonial Cities at the Beginning of the Twentieth Century', *Canadian Journal of African Studies*, 32 (1998), pp. 1–21.

5 P.A. Cole-King, 'Transport and Communication in Malawi', in Pachai (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi*, pp. 70–90; L. Vail, 'The Making of an Imperial Slum: Nyasaland and its Railways, 1895–1935', *Journal of African History*, 16 (1975), pp. 89–112.

Instead, the analysis reveals an active process in which fishers project models onto the landscape, creating a multi-layered waterscape on which to manoeuvre distances from micropolitical loci of power.

Labour Migration and the Lake

The lake's western shore situated on the northeastern tip of southern Africa, was a crucial site of European intervention in the latter half of the nineteenth century. David Livingstone 'discovered' the site and represented it as the centre for shipping slaves across the lake towards the Indian Ocean. His call to close this 'open sore of the world' attracted support from church-going circles in Britain, and justified colonial intervention in the area. Livingstone's famous slogan of 'commerce and Christianity' held that engagement in free trade with Christians in agricultural and mineral produce would emancipate the lakeshore residents from the slave trade. This slogan encouraged early missionary penetration in the lakeshore area, which in turn provided the population with an educational advantage.

The less quoted 'Livingstone myth'⁶ is also important. Livingstone insisted that the Zambezi was navigable, and to support this claim he consistently played down his own hardship in reaching the lake. His view was that the lake and its western basin should form a southward conduit to the ocean via the Zambezi. This aspiration to connect the lakeshore directly to the metropole, however, did not turn out to be economically viable. The British retained their interest in the area mainly as a barrier blocking Portuguese expansion in the region, and to serve Cecil Rhodes's ambition to secure the continent's north-south axis for Britain.

Before independence, the Nyasaland Protectorate lay deep in debt, which forced it to continue the 'commerce and Christianity' strategy of the Livingstonia Mission by 'exporting' labour through long-distance migration.⁷ The British redirected the flow of persons and goods across the lake on the west-east route, not through the waterway, but mostly nevertheless southwards, to colonial urban centres. The economic region of southern Africa has thus been partially produced through the 'satellisation' of the area.⁸ In contrast with neighbouring states, the satellite position of Nyasaland continued into the postcolonial period, because the Government of Malawi retained ties of dependency with South Africa. Thus, the legacies of Livingstone, early exposure to missionary education and a favourable position within the migrant labour market, would benefit the lakeshore residents.⁹

Contrary to the crisis school of labour migration studies, the effect of long distance labour migration to rural economies in the area has been deemed generally favourable in the literature.¹⁰ As Chanock points out, the process should be seen as a redistribution of power in social life, especially between generations and between men and women.¹¹

6 Cole-King, 'Transport and Communication in Malawi'.

7 Vail, 'The Making of an Imperial Slum'.

8 J. McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi 1875–1940: The Impact of the Livingstonia Mission in the Northern Province* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1977).

9 McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi*.

10 J. Van Velsen, 'Labour Migration as a Positive Factor in the Continuity of Tonga Tribal Society', in A. Southall (ed.), *Social Change in Modern Africa* (London, Oxford University Press, 1961), pp. 230–41; J. McCracken, 'Fishing and the Colonial Economy: The Case of Malawi', *Journal of African History*, 28 (1987), pp. 413–29; W.C. Chirwa, '"Theba is Power": Rural Labour, Migrancy, and Fishing in Malawi, 1890–1985' (Doctoral Dissertation, Queen University, Kingston, Ontario, 1992); M. Chanock, *Law, Custom and Social Order: The Colonial Experience in Malawi and Zambia* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1985). J. McCracken, 'Planters, Peasants and the Colonial State: The Impact of the Native Tobacco Board in the Central Province of Malawi', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 9, 2 (1983), pp. 172–92.

11 Chanock, *Law, Custom and Social Order*, p. 15.

Van Velsen noted in 1961 that, at any one time, between 60 and 75 per cent of adult males were absent and working outside Tongaland.¹² During their absence, the migrants themselves contributed actively to village life through remittances and manifold reciprocal services as part of normal kinship obligations. According to Van Velsen, Tonga men viewed their time in the village and labour migration as different phases of their lives:

Tonga working abroad belong to two contrasted and distinguishable (but not rigidly separated) economic and social environments [the rural and the urban areas] ... migration to the urban centres has become part of Tonga culture. The Tonga accept it as part of life that every normal man should spend at least some years away from Tongaland. They see Tongaland as a training ground for the young and a place of retirement for the old. **Young men consider their stay in the village, before they can go off to the towns, as a period of marking time ... Village and town have come to represent, for the men at least, different phases of life.**¹³

Van Velsen went on to predict that labour migration patterns would produce profound gender differences in life-experiences: 'Women ... do not expect to go abroad and few have ever gone. The result is that the knowledge, the experience and, one might almost say, the culture of the two sexes differ considerably.'¹⁴ Whilst some authors have argued that the colonial process, through Christianity and labour migration led to the disempowerment of women in the matrilineal belt,¹⁵ reducing the status of women from sisters to slaves,¹⁶ gender relations in fishery are more complex. Indeed, women's roles in fishery have been central rather than ancillary, which is why I prefer to use the gender-neutral term 'fisher' instead of 'fishermen'.¹⁷

The colonial interventions produced a morally differentiated landscape over the subcontinent to serve the needs of capitalism. The cities and villages were to be governed by separate legal systems, one serving economic production and the colonial administration, and the other, 'customary' law, which aimed to reproduce moral human beings. The cities were designated for African males of formal employment age, thus urban planners provided housing for single males. Women had no formal place in town and lived typically as 'prostitutes' forming *de facto* marital relationships with migrant men.¹⁸ **The idea was to extract productive labour as efficiently as possible whilst rural areas bore the costs of reproducing labour. The result was an urban-rural landscape differentiated by gender and generation, carrying moral tropes each associated with different forms of power: the 'colonial state', 'capitalism', and 'elders'. African males were expected to traverse back and forth across this landscape.**

Migrant labour and urbanity was to have its impact on gender and generation relations back in the fishing villages. Young, defiant, Tonga fishers also began to challenge their elders' control, using the proceeds of labour migration to buy their own fishing gear.¹⁹

Less frequently discussed than the effects of migrant labour in towns on fishing practices in villages, on gender and generational relationships, is its impact on the lakeshore residents' experience and imaginative reinterpretation of the waterscape. Over the generations, there

¹² Van Velsen, 'Labour Migration as a Positive Factor', p. 230.

¹³ *Ibid.*, pp. 230–36.

¹⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 236.

¹⁵ J. Davison, *Gender, Lineage, and Ethnicity in Southern Africa* (Oxford, CO, Westview, 1997).

¹⁶ M.L. Lovett, 'From Sisters to Wives and "Slaves": Redefining Matriliney and the Lives of Lakeside Tonga Women, 1885–1955', *Critique of Anthropology*, 17, 2, (1997), pp. 171–87.

¹⁷ See S. Nakayama (forthcoming) for an analysis of gender relations and issues of lake tenure.

¹⁸ J. Ferguson, *Expectations of Modernity: Myths and Meanings of Urban Life on the Zambian Copperbelt*, (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1999); L. White, *The Comforts of Home: Prostitution in Colonial Nairobi* (Chicago, IL, University of Chicago Press, 1990).

¹⁹ W.C. Chirwa, 'Technical Improvement, Social and Economic Relations in the Fishing Industry: the Case of the Chizi Area, Nkhata Bay District' (Honours Thesis, Chancellor College, University of Malawi, 1984).

has been a steady influx of men returning to the lakeshore with urban experience and capital to invest. One of these men was Paulo Manda,²⁰ whose children were also fully engaged in migrant labour.

Paulo Manda, the founder of the Manda compound (*kwaka* Paulo) had been to the Zambian Copperbelt. He also worked with the Fishery Department office in Nkhata Bay town. This made it possible for his son Michael and daughter Maggie to find positions in the Fisheries Department during the late 1980s and early 1990s under a UK/SADAC project. Michael gained training and experience as an electric welder. On termination of the project, he bought the welding machine and started his own welding shop in Nkhata Bay Town. During his youth he was briefly based at the sugar-cane plant at Dwangwa.

Maggie, in addition to her employment in the Fisheries Department, took on housekeeping positions in Lilongwe and Johannesburg. Now, when she is in Nkhata Bay she runs a grocery store selling cooldrinks, soap, and fishing lines; a position she concedes to the wife of Paulo's other son, Luka, during her long absences.

Perhaps Luka Manda, younger brother of Michael, has the most colourful career in urban labour. Upon graduating from a District Secondary School, he was recruited to a Computer School in South Africa as an instructor. After several years of employment, he decided to quit his job to return home to tend his mother who was ill. He drove all the way back to Nkhata Bay and into the village. His return is still legendary, his car was packed with all sorts of purchased goods: a television, video player and his computer. Out of his proceeds they built the first house with electricity in the village, purchased a nylon *chilimila* which was operated mainly by his father Paulo and brother, Michael (after they died the net was still called '*mkwawu*²¹ *waka Paulo*', Paulo's net), and established a bottlestore in Nkhata Bay town, where he befriended central political figures by buying them drinks. To incoming political figures holding government positions, the compound came to be known as '*kwaka Luka*' (Luka's place).

Previous reports have treated 'returned labour migrants' such as the Paulo family as advocates of the commercialisation of fishery.²² Settling in with new types of gear, they are said to have introduced technical and organisational innovations, most notably urban labour relations into the local fishery. The results have been represented as an irreversible destruction of the indigenous modes of fishing²³ Such teleological representations disregard any continuity in tenure regimes on the lake, and have been used to justify various reforms, including 'co-management' with the government and international development agencies in the postcolonial era.

This article challenges the view that indigenous fishing practices have been destroyed by returning male migrants interested only in commercialisation, by revealing the agency of Malawian fishers in remaking fishery practices and institutions. The Lakeside Tonga fishers do indeed form fishing units that resemble urban labour relations. However, I argue that their practice is not a disruptive break but an artful recombination of previously known techniques and organisations, which they represent and realise through urban-related terms. In my view, the transformation must not be seen as a passive, irreversible dislocation or dismemberment of a fishery and its economy from the village context. Instead, it is an active progress in which

20 The names of the informants cited in this article are all pseudonyms and have no bearing on their real names. I have chosen to indicate most by their childhood name and *chiwongo* (father's name), and left out the prefix 'Nya-' in its feminine form.

21 *Mkwawu* is a Tonga term for any type of large seine net including the *chilimila*.

22 Chirwa, 'Technical Improvement'; L. Kapeleta, 'The Coming of the Tonga and the Commercialization of Fishing in Monkey Bay Area: A Case Study' (unpublished paper, Department of Sociology, Chancellor College, University of Malawi, 1980).

23 Kapeleta, 'The Coming of the Tonga'.

fishers appropriate and project models onto the lake, creating a multi-layered waterscape on which they manoeuvre distances relative to different loci of power.

The Research

This study is based upon research primarily in Village-A on the western shore of Lake Malawi, near the town of Nkhata Bay. The village has a population of over 800 people who mostly speak the Tonga language, and who live in about 150 houses. I conducted field research in the village between December 1996 and March 2004, for a total period of 17 months.

The Tonga are known for their flexible social structure that renders them adaptive to change. Van Velsen and McCracken, among the few scholars to research the area, both emphasised the agency of the people they were looking at, especially in achieving rapid innovations in partial response to colonial processes. In light of developments that took place around the research site, I should add that agency also manifested in negotiating the patterns and timings of change. The tensions between missionaries and administration that shaped Nyasaland's political landscape seem to have contributed to the heterogeneity of Tonga colonial experience.

Village-A was well outside the 'missionary sphere of influence'²⁴ that elsewhere provided a *de facto* alternative to the colonial administration. Instead, the village's original location in Nkhata²⁵ subjected its residents to a violent encounter with colonialism. The place was targeted by the administration as a site to build a port and a government outpost to take control over the lake and its hinterland. As such, it received Tongaland's first tax collector and Resident Magistrate, C.A. Cardew, in 1897.²⁶ The upheaval²⁷ caused by the 20 untrained Yao askaris Cardew brought along compelled the District Headquarter to close down and relocate to Chinthche in just five years, leaving behind a rest-house and some of the askaris as a foothold.²⁸

Meanwhile, oral sources suggest that the askaris became integrated with the people of Nkhata through intermarriage. When the administration re-arrived in 1912 to implement the District Administration (Native) Ordinance, it was Village-A that had to relocate to the current site.²⁹ Subsequently, when the administration appointed five principal headmen for indirect rule in West Nyasa District,³⁰ the title went to the family associated with the Yao³¹ and has stayed there with the formalisation of the local authority structure under the colonial rule. The families that did not benefit from this appointment tend to attribute their political subordination to their lack of education at that time.³² 'We were too busy fishing to go to school', it is often remarked, 'We did not learn *Chizungu* (English) to befriend the *Azungu* (Europeans)'.³³ It is important to

24 J. Van Velsen, 'The Missionary Factor among the Lakeside Tonga of Nyasaland', *The Rhodes-Livingston Journal*, 26 (1960), pp. 1–22.

25 Currently known as Nkhata Bay.

26 C.A. Cardew, 'Nyasaland in the Nineties' *The Nyasaland Journal*, 8, 1 (1955), pp. 57–63.

27 Mwenda attributes the problems to tax increase and 'the cruel behaviour of the Yao policemen'. F. Mwenda 'Changes in the Society and Economy of Tongaland in the Late Nineteenth Century' (unpublished paper, Department of History, Chancellor College, University of Malawi, 1983).

28 Mwenda, *ibid.*; Cardew, 'Nyasaland in the Nineties'; J. Van Velsen, 'The Establishment of the Administration in Tongaland' (Salisbury, University College of Rhodesia and Nyasaland, 1962), pp. 177–95.

29 To be precise, the original village at Nkhata split into three villages and relocated to nearby sites. Village-A is one of them. The relocation is generally narrated to have been a peaceful process.

30 The present Nkhata Bay District.

31 Van Velsen notes that at Nkhata and Chinthche, the appointments of Principal Headmen may have been based on their proximity to the District Headquarters and their personnel. Van Velsen, 'The Establishment of the Administration in Tongaland.'

32 Such claims have been made by the families that have not benefited from the appointment.

33 The implication is that the 'Yao' agents had done otherwise.

recognise the significance of 'fishing' beyond mundane productive activity. The forefathers of Village-A are represented as busying themselves with their own politics while being disinterested in acquiring the means to approach newly arriving sources of power.

The Tonga of Nkhata Bay thus may not have enjoyed the 'politics of privilege'³⁴ compared with those living to their north, nor did they have the relative autonomy of those living south on the Chintheche strip.³⁵ The arrival of the colonial administration in 1897 contrasted with administration via the Livingstonia Mission.³⁶ As shown in cases of labour migration presented in this article, the job positions taken by migrants from Village-A do not necessarily fit the stereotypes of the educated elite. In terms of fishing, members of Village-A have not taken up new fishing methods as quickly as their counterparts just south of Nkhata Bay.³⁷

In Village-A and the stretch of rocky shore to its north, the introduction of new technologies has met with considerable resistance. This probably fuelled the southward migration of returned labour migrants investing in fishery – a push factor unmentioned in previous research. Authors such as Chirwa attribute the migration to the productivity of the southern fishing grounds. However, the 'Tonga migrant fishers' seem to originate mostly from the rocky shore further north in Thotho and Usisya (and closer to the Overtoun Institute).

'Just south of Nkhata Bay' is the Chizi area within Nkhata Bay District, just two hours walk from Village-A. According to Chirwa, the place served as a testing ground for the Nkhata Bay Fisheries Office in Nkhata Bay town, and fuelled various rapid 'technology-based innovations' in fishing. Chizi area lies at the intersection between the rocky and sandy shores, and was apparently unoccupied by the rocky shore fishers. Chirwa does acknowledge the social constraints to innovation in the area north of Chizi, and how they may have shaped migration and development patterns in Lake Malawi fishing. However, his description of 'communal fishing' north of Chizi as a practice of the past³⁸ creates an image of fundamental discontinuity between practices that constitute 'communal' and 'commercial' fishing.

Oral sources suggest that during the 1950s and 1960s, at the height of the southward migration of 'Tonga fishers', the movement bypassed Village-A and its neighbouring area. It was after the decline of the fishery in the southern end of the lake that 'Tonga fishers' in the area began to seek alternative fishing grounds, and began to migrate back north to settle within Tongaland but outside their home area. A number of prominent *chilimila* fishers have settled in the vicinity of Nkhata Bay. As we will see, fisher Jumpha did not exactly follow this U-turn of Tonga fishers, but he came at a time when nylon *chilimila* fishers were settling in the area.

The adoption of *kampani* and nylon *chilimila* described in the next section is but one aspect of the transformation. For example, the introduction of lamps required another set of developments, which are not discussed in this article, and is connected to discourses of deforestation. The discontinuation of the scoop net, on the other hand, required a witch-finding trial that led to the precipitation of political factions within the village. The transformation process outlined in this article is represented in its simplest and most positive form, in the way that the headmen like to narrate history.

Thus, the view that the Tonga are responsible for destroying indigenous fishing methods seems exaggerated. Indeed, I have observed older fishing methods in use at the southern end

34 McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi*.

35 J. Van Velsen, *Ibid.*

36 McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi*.

37 Chirwa, 'Technical Improvement'.

38 Placing certain practices firmly in the past is a typical way of obscuring information about ongoing, politically sensitive issues related to the subject.

of the lake. Previous research has often taken narratives at face value, and has failed to consider the politics of representation, or the observation of actual practices.

As has been previously reported, fishing is a predominantly male activity, one that is important in the construction of Tonga male personhoods. However, this is only relevant if fishing is defined in the narrowest sense: as the actual wielding of gear in the water, to catch fish as a livelihood, and not for subsistence alone. Yet if fishing is defined more broadly, the important roles played by women can be seen more clearly.

Previous studies³⁹ have represented Tonga women as holding ancillary roles in fishing, such as the processing and trading of fish. However, if fishing skills make up an integral part of Tonga male personhood, Tonga women could not be considered mature without having acquired the knowledge of processing and trading fish. My field observations show that although women do engage in fish processing and trading if the catch is large, in reality these activities are not restricted to women. There are male traders and processors, who tend to outcompete their female counterparts in terms of capital and mobility. Neither are female contributions in fishery restricted to processing and trading of the catch. Women also fish, if only for home consumption. At times they have contributed indispensable daily labour in major fishing methods. In the torch-and-scoop net (*chiwu*) method (described below), women have literally fuelled the fishing by supplying torch material. Finally, previous studies have almost entirely ignored women's centrality to fishing in the symbolic domain, from the creation of places both in the water and on the land to the control of fish behaviour. Some important fishing grounds are associated with particular women. The association between the fertility of fishing grounds and female reproduction is sought in fishery rituals (such cases are reported from a wide area including the islands and the opposite shore). Women are often thought to have the power to control the behaviour of fish from their homes. Seen in this way, the role of women in fishing has been central rather than ancillary. Many women would claim that the catch of fish rightfully belonged to them and not to the 'fishermen'.

Fishing Techniques in Village-A

Fishers in Village-A employ a host of line-and-net-based methods. A key fish is *usipa* (*Engraulicypris sardella*), a small shoaling cyprinid endemic to Lake Malawi, similar in appearance and usage to freshwater sardines found in other African lakes. Not only are *usipa* important as food, they also comprise the majority of the catch with respect to tonnage. Marketed fresh or dry *usipa* are important economic goods. Their importance as bait also makes them integral to the overall fishery in the area – a catch of *usipa* makes a host of line-based methods possible, and for this reason, at least one net per beach will try to remain active even during the low season. The *usipa* fishery makes use of a *chilimila*,⁴⁰ a large open-water seine net,⁴¹ in combination with paraffin-fuelled pressure lamps to

39 M.C. Hoole, 'Notes on Fishing and Allied Industries as Practised amongst the Tonga of the West Nyasa District', *The Nyasaland Journal*, 8, 1 (1955), pp. 25–38; McCracken, 'Fishing and the Colonial Economy'; G. Haraldsdottir, 'Cooperation and Conflicting Interests: An Ethnography of Fishing and Fish Trading on the Shores of Lake Malawi' (Ph.D. thesis, University of Iowa, 2002).

40 Similar net names appear in the literature: '*chilimila*', '*chirimila*' and '*chilimira*'. Judging from the description and context they are merely variations in spelling: consonants [l] and [r] are not distinguished in the Lakeside Tonga language and letters 'l' and 'r' are often used interchangeably in writing. Here I use the spelling '*chilimila*'.

41 The *chilimila* is often described as a seine-net since it catches mainly by enclosing fish instead of trapping them in the mesh. However, it is unique in structure and operation compared with any conventional net in that it first circles the target shoal like a purse seine or shore seine, then sinks and scoops it up like a lift net (see below). This dynamic three-dimensional action is controlled by the balance of floats and weights, the hydrodynamics of the current and the drawing speed. Furthermore, its mesh-size varies within a single net to function also as a gill net

attract fish.⁴² As such, it is often associated with the Tonga fishers.⁴³ Fishers are organised into units called *kampani*. This net-based method and the *kampani* organisation were introduced to Village-A in the 1980s.

I will now consider the remaking of fishery practices and the deployment of urban metaphor in the representation of fisheries. I begin by describing the methods that formed the basis for the current method: the *chilimila* net method used to catch cichlids,⁴⁴ and the *usipa* method, which uses a torch and scoop net (*chiwu*). The former is still in use in the research area, while the latter ceased in the early 1990s. All fishing is conducted from dugout canoes.

Chilimila Fishing for *Mtaka*⁴⁵ Cichlids

Chilimila nets are believed to have been first used by fishers on northern Lake Malawi. According to a survey conducted in the Nkhata Bay area in the 1950s, the net was introduced to the lake islands of Likoma and Chizumulu in the 1870s by Arabs. Around 1900, the use of *chilimila* had reached the western shore at Bandawe, arriving at Nkhata Bay soon afterwards.⁴⁶ Considering that the main residents of Nkhata Bay at that time were said to have just returned from anti-Ngoni fortresses built near Bandawe or had migrated from Likoma Island, this timeline seems quite feasible. By the 1930s, *chilimila* had become popular among Nkhata Bay fishers.⁴⁷

The *chilimila*, when laid flat, has an oval shape (see Figure 1). The net is operated from two dugouts, each boarded by two to three persons (Figure 2). The target *mtaka* are known to swim in shoals around underwater rocky protrusions called *chirundu* (pl. *virundu*).⁴⁸ Fishers locate the *chirundu* based on the relative position of terrestrial clues visible from the lake. From the direction of the current, they deduce the shoal position and the net-casting point. The two dugouts approach the point side by side, each carrying the left and right halves of the net. On reaching the point they part, casting the net in between them in a half circle (Figure 2(a)). They then row in the direction of the current until the net opens into the shape of a tilted basin, facing the *chirundu*. The net is subsequently hauled in by pulling ropes tied at wooden poles near the foot rope. This pulling causes the foot rope to move ahead of the head rope and along the *chirundu* wall, effectively scooping up the shoal of fish (Figure 2(b)). After

Footnote 41 continued

corresponding to fish of different size. For a fully detailed description, see: P.B.N. Jackson, T.D. Iles, D. Harding and G. Fryer, *Report on the Survey of Northern Lake Nyasa: 1954–55* (Zomba, Government Printer, 1963); G. Fryer, 'Local Knowledge of the Fishes of the Ancient Lakes of Africa, and an Example of Comprehensive Understanding', in H. Kawanabe, G.W. Coulter, A.C. Roosevelt (eds), *Ancient Lakes: Their Cultural and Biological Diversity* (Ghent, Kenobi Productions, 1999), pp. 263–70.

42 This combination of gear is now called *kauni* fishery at other parts of the lake, and is often represented as a destructive foreign fishing technique introduced by the Tonga.

43 A recent analysis by Francis Maguza-Tembo revealed that the method itself is not necessarily destructive, even at the very fishing grounds where it has attracted the most criticism. Such evidence suggests that the labelling of certain fishing methods and techniques as destructive may well be politically motivated. See F. Maguza-Tembo, 'Population Parameters and Exploitation Rate of *Engraulicypris sardella* and *Rhamphochromis* Species in Southern Lake Malawi: Case of Light Attraction Fishery' (United Nations University Fisheries Training Programme, Final Project, 2004).

44 Cichlids are a large group of fresh water fish species similar in appearance to perch. Lake Malawi has the highest number of cichlid species in the world with estimates ranging from several hundred to over a thousand, most of which are endemic to the lake.

45 *Mtaka* is a fish category in the Tonga ethno-ichthyology that corresponds to haplochromine cichlids of the *Copadichromis* and *Mchenga* genera. Typically about the size of a palm, many are found shoaling in mid-water near the shore. Its Chewa language counterpart *utaka* is adopted for scientific use.

46 Jackson, Iles, Harding and Fryer, *Report on the Survey of Northern Lake Nyasa*.

47 M.C. Hoole, 'Notes on Fishing and Allied Industries as Practiced Amongst the Tonga of the West Nyasa District', *The Nyasaland Journal*, 8, 1 (1955), pp. 25–38; Chirwa, 'Technical Improvement'.

48 Jackson, Iles, Harding and Fryer, *Report on the Survey of Northern Lake Nyasa*.

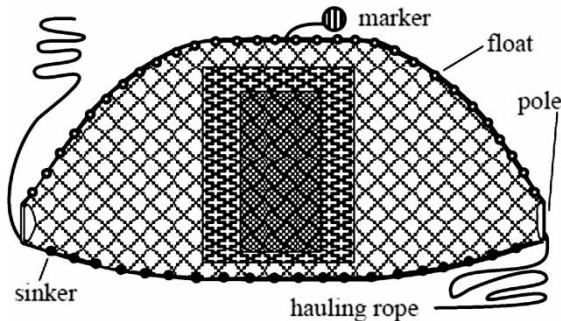


Figure 1. The structure of a *chilimila*. Nylon nets are sewn together between the headrope and footrope (approximately 60 and 40 m, respectively), attached at both ends to two wooden poles. Wooden floats and stone sinkers are attached to the head and foot ropes at an interval of 2 m. A large marker float is tied to the middle of the headrope by a rope 3–4 m in length. A hauling rope is tied to each wooden pole near the footrope. The mesh size decreases towards the centre of the net. In *usipa* fishing, the outer large-mesh is lined with mosquito netting.

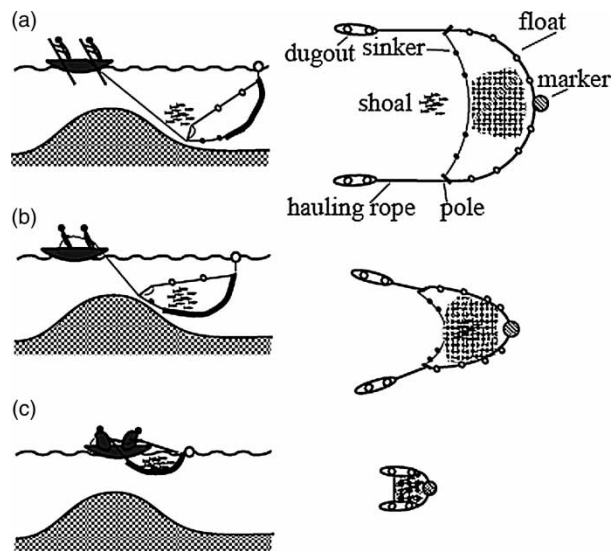


Figure 2. The operation of a *chilimila*.

the wooden poles are reached, the foot rope is pulled in before the head rope, breaking the surface to form a bag hanging in the water where the fish are caught. The catch is retrieved into the dugout as the whole net is taken in, so that when the process is over, the net is already split between the two dugouts, ready for another cast. The process takes about 10 to 15 minutes from the casting to the haul.

The *chilimila* is efficient, considering the size of the net relative to the number of persons and the time required to operate it. The success of this fishing method depends on the expertise of the fishers as well as their knowledge of *mtaka* behaviour, their use of terrestrial clues to locate the fishing ground, the three-dimensional space underwater which the net should traverse, and the fishers' reading of the changing currents and the dynamics of the net as it sinks and spreads in mid-water. Its operation thus requires the co-ordination of the knowledge of multiple factors as they move through time and space at considerable speed. Failure means not only having to return empty handed, but also possible destruction of the net if it hits the *chirundu* and tears apart. This method has been described in detail in the survey report

mentioned above.⁴⁹ The method of identifying *virundu* and their actual locations has remained basically the same.

According to several reports, Nkhata Bay fishers were using lights in combination with the *chilimila* to fish at night as early as the 1930s.⁵⁰ By this method, a third dugout bearing a torch paddles slowly towards the net and stops beside the marker float until the head rope breaks the surface. The light-bearing dugout then rows out of the net, crossing over the head rope to leave the shoal inside. Target fish include *Mormyrus* spp., *Bathyclarias* spp., and an occasional *Bagrus meridionalis*, in addition to various kinds of *mtaka*.

A *chilimila* is constructed by sewing together nylon nets between the head rope and foot rope (approximately 60 and 40 m, respectively), attached at both ends to two wooden poles. Wooden floats and stone sinkers are attached to the head and foot ropes at an interval of 2 m. A large marker float is tied to the middle of the head rope by a rope 3 to 4 m in length. A hauling rope is tied to each wooden pole near the foot rope. The mesh size decreases towards the centre of the net. In *usipa* fishing, the outer large-mesh is lined with mosquito netting.⁵¹

The *chilimila* method requires four to six fishers for operation and a great deal of skill and labour to maintain the equipment. Labour recruitment and catch distribution in cash were initially confined within kin groups. Before the 1980s, the nets were produced from local plant material, mainly the *tchopwa* shrub (*Pouzolzia hypoleuca*). Since the crafting and maintenance of the nets were particularly labour intensive, only persons of status such as village heads and the like, who could draw on the labour of a large male kin group, could ever become a net owner. Thus, the net tended to be identified with the village or hamlet. Every net had a name of its own and was somewhat personified, as fishers talked to their net during the process of mending. Although the current net materials have been replaced by nylon, the application of various herbs and charms is still considered important in ensuring the performance of this type of gear. Fishers now form themselves into units called *kampani*, to organise labour and to distribute the catch. In addition, a host of urban-related terms have been introduced, a process I shall turn to later.

The *Chiwu*-Torch Method of *Usipa* Fishing

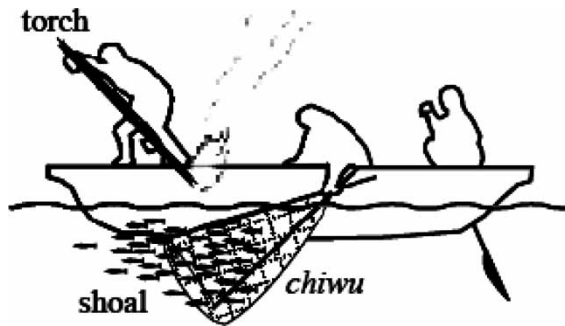
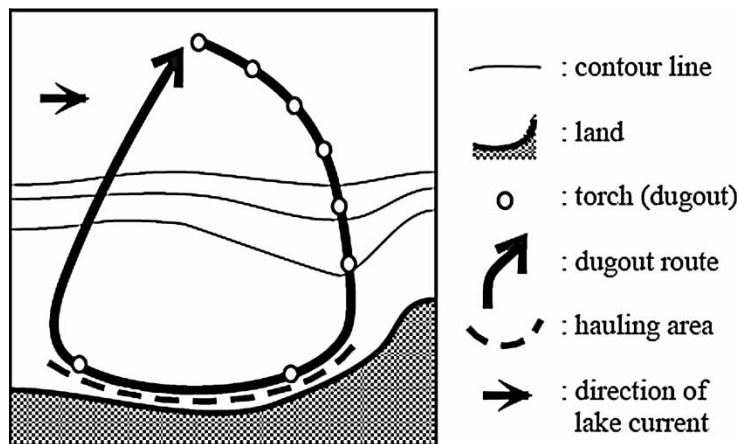
The *chiwu*-torch method takes place at night, when the moon is below the horizon or in its dark phase. The fishers attract *usipa* by using the light of a bamboo torch and then catch the fish using a *chiwu*, a type of scoop net made from the fine-meshed fibre of the *tchopwa* shrub. The net is attached between two poles about 1.2 to 1.5 m in length. The torch is made of bamboo which has been split and bundled together into a cylindrical shape of up to 2 m. Three fishers board one dugout, with each one holding the torch, the *chiwu*, or the paddle, respectively (Figure 3). Then they row the dugout against the current, with the torch smouldering in the bottom of the dugout. The direction they take depends on the lake currents on a given night. When the party is far enough from shore, the torch is set ablaze. The fishers wait for tiny bubbles to appear on the surface – a sign of a shoal ascending towards the light. The party then starts paddling slowly back towards the shore.

The success of this fishery is considered to depend on the fisher's ability to predict the behaviour of the shoal and to adjust the course and speed accordingly on the return to shore.

49 *Ibid.*, pp. 146–50.

50 Chirwa, 'Technical Improvement'; Hoole, 'Notes on Fishing'; Jackson, Iles, Harding and Fryer, *Report on the Survey of Northern Lake Nyasa*.

51 S. Nakayama, 'Fishing with "Outsiders": Villager-Migrant Relations on Northern Lake Malawi', *Proceedings of Kyoto Symposium: Crossing Disciplinary Boundaries and Re-visioning Area Studies*, Kyoto, ASAFAS/CSEAS, 2006), pp 385–95.

Figure 3(a). The *chiwu*-torch method of *usipa* fishing.Figure 3(b). Fishing ground for the *chiwu*-torch method.

Shoals do not always reach the surface, and the fishers must watch closely for bubbles or the occasional appearance of some individual fish at the surface. These are important clues to the depth and density of the shoal and the speed at which they are swimming. On some nights shoals reach the surface, with individual fish jumping from the water. The rocky substrate of this area delimits the route fishers can take to guide the fish. On a good route, the substrate could serve as a funnel compressing a shoal dispersed in deep water into the shallows. However, the substrate could also block the fish, causing them to scatter and turn back.

When a party nears the shore, the dugout turns to the right, keeping the torch to the left, with the shoal between itself and the shore. The person holding the scoop net starts scooping the shoal into the dugout as the boat proceeds along the shore. The torch-holder moves the torch in accordance with the net, sprinkling the flare with water to dim the light and to concentrate the shoal further. On reaching the river mouth, where the cold water is believed to cause the shoal to scatter, the dugout turns back offshore to attract more *usipa*.

The three fishers in each dugout tend to be close kin, such as a father and sons or brothers living in the same household. Villagers recall that gathering torch material was a very cumbersome task, which was performed mainly by the women of each household. The catch and cash were distributed among close kin.

The *chiwu* method called for close co-ordination among fishers. The limited course for guiding the shoal inshore, and the subsequent scooping of the shoal, specified the fishing ground where this method was used. Daily fluctuating currents further determined the route of

the dugout. When more than two dugouts fished, they had to move along the same route. In guiding the shoal, dugouts were expected to form a line, keeping a certain distance from each other in order to avoid interference caused by the lights. This was important for several reasons. First, the merging of the lights might cause the shoal to disperse, rendering it impossible to direct the shoal. Furthermore, if any fish were caught under merged lights, disputes could arise as to whose light had lured the fish and how the catch should be divided. Fishers from adjacent fishing grounds took care not to let their routes intersect for the same reasons. This practice of forming lines constitutes the only overtly expressed set of rules concerning the use of fishing grounds in the research area.

There are, however arrangements of a more covert nature associated with the *usipa* fishery. Fishers who share the same route have, on many occasions, set up divination devices that serve to regulate the actual nights on which fishing occurs. The ritual knowledge for the divinations is even more strictly guarded than the knowledge of which magical substances should be applied to the net. This ensures that only a select few fishers of the area can implement this practice.

The Current *Usipa* Fishery

Currently, fishers of Village-A use the light of paraffin pressure lamps to attract offshore shoals of *usipa*; the fish are then lured closer to shore with the light and hauled in with a *chilimila* (Figure 4(a)). The only substantial differences between the two methods described above are the light source (paraffin lamps are used in place of the torch), the net (the *chilimila* in place of the *chiwu*), and the net material (nylon in place of locally produced natural fibre). The route through which the shoals are led and the way in which multiple lights line up are the same as in the *chiwu*-torch method (Figure 4(b)), and the operation of the *chilimila* is the same as in the *mtaka* fishing described above.

The current fishing units are called *kampani*. These units comprise the gear owner, who may or may not fish him/herself, four to six fishers operating the net, and one or two lamp bearers, making a total of five to nine people. Fishing stops for several nights straddling the full moon, and the accumulated cash is distributed at a pre-arranged rate, regardless of the receivers' relationship to the gear owner. One of the fishers, who is not the gear owner, handles the catch operation and distribution, and is called the *hedi* (head). The gear owner takes half the share and provides the paraffin, netting, and other related materials. The rest of the sum is shared equally among the members. For example, if dugouts are borrowed, the

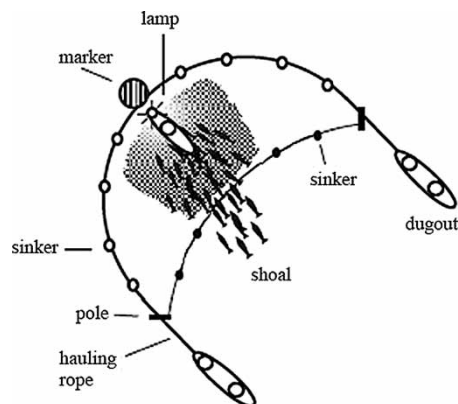


Figure 4(a). The *chilimila*-lamp method for *usipa* fishing.

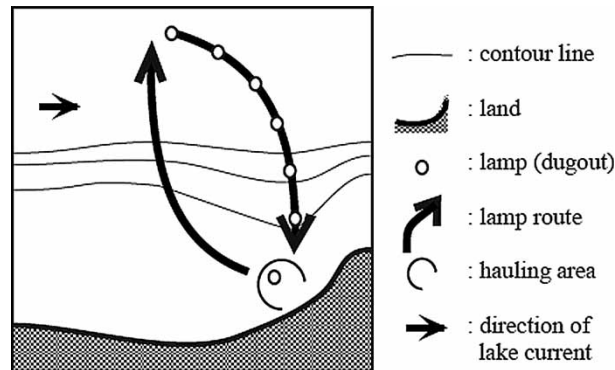


Figure 4(b). Fishing ground for the *chilimila*-lamp method.

dugout owner is counted as a member of the *kampani*, and receives a share. Nets, however, are never borrowed. In principle, members do not have to be kin of the gear owner to participate in a *kampani*, and the timing and ration of the catch distribution are pre-arranged.

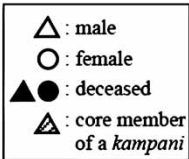
The rules concerning the lining up of the lamps have been modified to include the order in which the lamps should line up. Lamps working for different *chilimila* are expected to be arranged alternately to ensure equal fishing opportunities among *kampani*. The ritual practices of both the *chilimila* and the fishing grounds have been in practice in the recombined method.

The Transformation of Fishing Organisation and Method in Village-A

The formation of *kampani* and use of the *chilimila* and lamp method are the major changes that have taken place in the *usipa* fishery of Village-A. The process of innovation is outlined below, particularly with regard to the negotiations between migrant and villagers, which in the case of Village-A had been catalysed by Jumpha Banda.

Jumpha moved into Village-A in 1979. His father had moved into Village-A a year earlier; he had no kinship or prior ties with the villagers but was allowed to establish a residence in a section allocated to 'outsiders'. Jumpha had worked as a fisher on Lake Tanganyika. Upon his return to Malawi, he decided to live with his father, instead of at his original home, north of Nkhata Bay. He started fishing in front of the village with a nylon *chilimila* he had brought with him.

At first, Jumpha fished with his nearby kin using the *mtaka* method. Although he shared part of his catch in kind with the villagers, he sold the bulk of the fish and never shared the cash outside his kin. The villagers considered this as a problem because they were not benefiting from fishing that had taken place at their village. Jumpha's *mtaka* fishery was essentially the same as those of the villagers, except for the material of his net. Because his fishing unit was kinship based, he was simply following the practice of the villagers by sharing the cash among his kinship group. The villagers raised their claim to his catch because Jumpha was landing large catches, despite being an 'outsider'. They summoned Jumpha to the elders' meeting. Jumpha responded to their claim by proposing that he form a *kampani* that would incorporate the villagers as members, instead of distributing the cash directly. This would mean that the villagers would receive a share of cash at a prearranged rate. According to the normal fixed ratio, the villagers would receive no more than a quarter of the share, even if they comprised half of the members. Although this does not seem like a large figure, once cash enters the kinship circle, it circulates in various forms. It is also likely



friend Simon.

that the villagers thought it important that Jumpha accept the claim, as it would constitute an acknowledgement that the lake in front of the village was theirs.

The concept of *kampani* was thus introduced to Village-A via *mtaka* fishing practices to enable fishers without kinship relations to work together. In turn, the villagers invited Jumpha, with whom they had by then established an amicable relationship, into their *usipa* fishery divination arrangements. At this time, the nylon *chilimila* and lamps were being used widely for fishing *usipa* on many parts of the lake; however, the methods used at Village-A differed greatly from those in other areas. Specifically, in other areas, both the light attraction and net hauling took place far offshore,⁵² and fishers did not have to lead the shoal inshore using lamps. This method was employed mainly in shallow parts of the lake. In contrast, in Village-A, fishers applied their method of leading the shoal inland, thereby maintaining their co-operative relationship with respect to their usage of the fishing ground (for example, forming the line of dugouts). Moreover, the villagers were already familiar with the light-attraction method in combination with the *chilimila*. The change, then, involved the replacement of the torch with the lamp and the scoop net with the *chilimila*. Mosquito netting was also attached to the *chilimila* to create a fine mesh. To sum up, pre-existing methods were recombined. *Kampanis* began to form thereafter among fishers who had bought nylon *chilimilas*.

Since the introduction of the nylon *chilimila* and *kampani* in *usipa* fishery, fishers with capital began to convert from the *chiwu*-torch method and to buy their own nylon *chilimila* to start their *kampani*. The first to convert were labour migrants who had returned to settle in their original village. They either invested their retirement fee, or remittances from their sons working as migrant labourers, in the net. Drawing on their knowledge of urban labour relations, they invented and applied specific roles within the *kampani*.⁵³ During May through December, 1998, three *kampanis* were in operation. Figure 5 shows the genealogy of the main participants (those that fished more than three times) of one of the *kampani*. This *kampani* had 19 participants in total, of which nine are shown in the figure. Most were related to the net owner. The net owner (*mweneku wamkwawu*) tends to regard his fishers as the whole junior male kin group whose co-operation he can rely on, and he calls them the ‘owners of the net’ (*weneku wamkwawu*). Note that ‘ownership’ in this sense is always contested and the boundary is left unclear – this is done deliberately by including many fishers (ten fishers in

52 As with the method *kauni*.

53 For instance, James Longwe's invention of his *manejala* status (see below).

this case) who fish only once or twice with the net, who may or may not be related to the net owner.

The *kampani* illustrated in the figure is that of James Longwe, which he founded with his elder brother Kenes Longwe. Born in 1926, James learnt much of his fishery skills at his natal village until age 17 when he moved to live with his mother in Village-A. His career in long-distance labour migration began in 1947 when he was 21 years old, and continued until 1975 when he was 49. James's first job was at an electric power utility in South Africa, working as a 'selufu',⁵⁴ migrant. According to James, the firm preferred Tonga workers because of the relatively long periods they worked as compared with contract workers arriving through government recruiters. However, he soon left and joined his friend Simon in Port Nolloth, South Africa, at the Atlantic fishery. Tonga migrants were preferred recruits in the fishing industry, he explained to me, because of their knowledge in the handling and mending of fishnets. The fishing vessel he worked on was at sea for months on end before he could return to shore. He described his amazement at how they 'packed, packed, packed, food and everything on board'. James continued to work for the Atlantic fishery, returning home infrequently for only a few months at a time. He married a South African woman whom he brought back home to Malawi.

James's elder brother, Kenes has also worked in South Africa. The Longwe brothers jointly invested their proceeds in the nylon *chilimila* once they had seen 'their friends landing good catch[es]'. Kenes seldom goes fishing; he considers himself a farmer and would rather spend his time in the cassava fields with his wife than on the water. Nevertheless, as a respected net owner, he comes down to the beach at night with other village elders for a chat. **Together they sit on a dugout beached at arm's length from the hustle, pressuring young fishers with their perceived magical powers.**

James, on the other hand, is an avid fisher. He is among the most active fishers in Village-A, and takes a portion of the *usipa* caught at night as bait before going off at dawn again to handline for cichlids. In *usipa* fishery he virtually runs the whole operation, giving directions not only to his crew but to all the fishers sharing the fishing ground. Although his investment in the net is a shared one, he likes to call himself a *manejala*, a position he manoeuvres between Kenes 'the net owner' and the *hedi* who shares out the catch. The one non-kin member of his *kampani*, is the lamp bearer and son of Simon, a central member of a major village clan. Simon is his long-time friend with whom he shares much of his urban labour experiences in the Atlantic fishery.

Every *kampani* in operation included at least one 'outsider' who, while not part of the *weneku wamkwawu*, played a central role in the operation, such as the *hedi* or the lamp bearer. Villagers generally say that including 'outsiders' in the *kampani* makes it easier for fishers to resist requests for shares from kin who did not participate in the fishing. This arrangement is thought to be essential for attaining shares at a fixed rate. However, all *kampani* retain the practices of obligatory shares of catch to close kin residing in Village-A.

A point of interest may be the shift of focus in the logic applied in the formation of *kampani*. Jumpha initially proposed the introduction of *kampani* as a means of sharing labour and wealth between those without kinship relations. The villagers accepted this as an acknowledgement that they were the autochthons and should therefore benefit. When current villagers form *kampani*, however, they include members without kinship-relations in order to secure both the allocations to kin residing in the village, and to cover the running costs of fishery, which may require the denial of shares to non-resident kin. The multivalent usage of a

54 An informal and self-organised type of labour migration that the Lakeside Tonga often engaged in, as opposed to migrant work via government recruiters.

kampani organisation leads us to regard its introduction not as the disintegration of kinship organisation in fishery, but instead, the reconstitution of kin group boundaries.

This leads to an important reconsideration and advancement of the pioneering ethnography of Jaap Van Velsen. Based on fieldwork in the 1950s, Van Velsen emphasised the flexibility of Tonga society, conceptualising it as a 'wide network of relationships between individuals and small kin groups rather than through a structured ranking and co-ordination of clearly defined and permanent local or kinship units'.⁵⁵ He recognised the network extending beyond the rural areas into the urban centres through male labour migration. And, as noted earlier, the urban migrants contributed to the continuity of rural Tonga life by 'stimulating traditional values'.⁵⁶ His findings proved an effective counter argument to structuralist approaches, bringing back the individual into anthropological theory. Although his observations seem largely appropriate, he did create a contradiction between an image of a static rural Tonga society,⁵⁷ and the flexible social manoeuvres that he described in his later ethnography in which urban life had little space.⁵⁸

As my research suggests, in the everyday context, 'the politics of kinship' manifests itself as 'the politics of relish' and cash.⁵⁹ The 'small kin groups'⁶⁰ as political and economic units, however temporal and flexible, used *kampani* fishery as a means of managing distribution of food and cash in the case of Village-A. The incorporation of non-kin members and the use of urban ethics and metaphors serve as markers to differentiate the activity from the kinship-based ideology of rural life. By delimiting cash transactions to the lake and the village shore, the village as an ideological domain is preserved on the land. Thus, appropriating the urban becomes a means of continuing and reinforcing rural values in the flexible and manipulative sense Van Velsen argued in both of his works.

The Invention of *Baragelu*

The line of organisational innovations did not stop with the formation of *kampani*. The application of urban metaphors in fishery is epitomised by the invention of the *baragelu* (bar girl) status. The success of *kampanis* attracted fishers who wanted to join. Since the number of people pulling the net had to be limited, those who joined took on the role of the lamp bearer. By 1985, when there were more lamps than one *kampani* could cover the cost of paraffin, a young fisher asked to join. He had his own lamp, which is much less expensive than the net, and insisted that he cover his own fuel. The net owner was Jumpha again, and he proposed: 'From now on you are *baragelu*. You can come to my net tonight, and tomorrow, to another.' A *baragelu* fisher may fish with any net and receive the immediate return of a third to half of the catch he attracts that night. Just like 'bar girls', such fishers have the freedom of being detached from any particular *kampani*, and when successful can quickly raise lucrative amounts of money.

During the data collection period, 46 fishers had participated at least for one night for the three *kampani* as a '*baragelu*'. For all *kampani*, it was the *baragelu* that attracted the bulk of the catch and the cash that went into the *kampani*. The *baragelu* could not fish without the nets of the *kampani*, but the *kampani* could not economically sustain itself without the participation of *baragelu*.

55 Van Velsen, 'Politics of Kinship', p. 313.

56 Van Velsen, 'Labor Migration', p. 241.

57 *Ibid.*

58 Van Velsen did, however, acknowledge that labour migration was considered 'the only way to escape from a difficult situation' at home. Van Velsen, 'Politics of Kinship', p. 67.

59 H.L. Moore and M. Vaughan, *Cutting Down Trees: Gender, Nutrition and Agricultural Change in the Northern Province of Zambia, 1890–1990* (London, James Currey, 1994).

60 Van Velsen, 'Politics of Kinship'.

Yet another striking feature of the *baragelu* is that most are from the newcomer group and do not have kinship relations with the net owner. Furthermore, they are not expected to perform in any of the fishing rituals, and perhaps more important, have the freedom to 'not know' or 'pretend not to know' of such practices. The vitality of the current fishery depends on the collaboration of fishers who position themselves differently with regards to participation, transaction and the sharing of knowledge.

Fishery statistics for Nkhata Bay show that the 1990s saw a shift in main catch species from *utaka* (*mtaka*) to *usipa*, and the increased importance of *chilimila* in the fishery compared with other equipment.⁶¹ These data roughly correspond to my field observations, although Village-A has always been known for its focus on *usipa*.

The general view of Nkhata Bay fishers seems to be that the decline of fish stock at the southern end of the lake has caused small-scale commercial 'Tonga fishermen' to seek better fishing and marketing opportunities elsewhere.⁶² Another important development was the construction of the tarmac road connecting Nkhata Bay to Mzuzu, a city then in rapid growth. This dramatically improved marketing opportunities at Nkhata Bay, which expanded as a regional hub. This opened the lakeshore flanking the port within approximately four hours of rowing distance to the previously non-existent trade in fresh fish. The expansion of the trade in fresh fish took away women's trading opportunities, since men would 'escape' to the waters to sell their catch, fresh and at better rates, instead of handing it to their women to process.

These changes made the vicinity of Nkhata Bay a small but reasonable destination for fishers leaving the southern lakeshore for better fishing grounds as well as for newly returned migrants. Fishery transformation gradually moved northwards, towards the migrant Tonga fishers' original homes.

The area situated on the stretch of rocky shoreline north of Nkhata Bay, where many of the most innovative 'Tonga fishers' originated, was the last to accept the *chilimila*-lamp method in *usipa* fishery. Previous reports have attributed the southward migration of fishers solely to the scarcity of fish stock in their home area. What they have failed to observe was the intricate set of often unspoken or covert norms that facilitated co-operation between fishers on their home ground. '*Kuno kwe chigawa; kumwera kulivi*' (here there are territories [in the water]; in the south there aren't.); [Headman, Village-A]. Although territories on the lake are non-exclusive and very seldom expressed, their importance lies in the advantage that the owners of any territory can establish in negotiation over various issues including who enters the fishing ground, the arrangement of the 'line' of dugouts in the *chihu*-torch method, and the distribution of the catch and profits. For returned labour migrants, who aspired to make much profit out of the fishery, fishing at 'home' had its own obstacles: the burden of negotiation with their own elders in trying out new methods and organisations, as well as their obligations through kinship and other relationships in sharing

61 G.Z. Kanyere, W. Namoto and O.C. Mponda, 'Analysis of Catch and Effort Data for the Fisheries of Nkhata Bay, Lake Malawi, 1976–1999', *Fisheries Bulletin*, 48 (2001), pp. 1–15.

62 Note the performative use of the ethnic label 'Tonga'. The 'southerners' will identify them with the stereotype: 'if on land, a Tumbuka; if on water, a Tonga'. Much of the migrant fishers originate from the northern end of Tongaland, closer to the Overtoun Institute, where many would identify themselves as Tumbuka, Msiska, etc. However, they would accept being labelled Tonga when fishing on the southern end for sake of simplicity. For the colonial and postcolonial creations of ethnicities and their conflation with regionalism in the northern Nyasaland/Malawi context, see: L. Vail and L. White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', in L. Vail (ed.), *The Creation of Tribalism in Southern Africa* (London, James Curry, 1989), pp. 151–92; J. McCracken, 'The Ambiguities of Nationalism: Flax Musopole and the Northern Factor in Malawian Politics, c. 1956–1966', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 28, 1 (2002), pp. 64–87; D. Kaspin, 'The Politics of Ethnicity in Malawi's Democratic Transition', *The Journal of Modern African Studies*, 33, 4 (1995), pp. 595–620.

their catch in cash and kind. Their choice destination would thus have been the southern end of the lake with bountiful fish stocks, where nobody, at least not the autochthons, would recognise them at all. Once the fish stocks began to fall there, the western shores in Tongaland became a reasonable choice with marketing opportunities, provided they were far enough from home to be accepted as ‘outsiders’ with no pressure to identify themselves as kin of original residents. We should note here that Jumpha could have claimed any putative or distant kinship links to the original residents of Village-A, much in the style Van Velsen had portrayed, but he chose not to do so.

Conclusion

It is tempting to attribute the transformation of the *usipa* fishery in Village-A simply to the nylon *chilimila* and lamp combination, brought in by migrants, that was spreading along the lake at that time. However, a more nuanced argument is that the transformation actually emerged from a *bricolage* of pre-existing methods and organisations of various origin that were based on the villagers’ knowledge of their environment. In the case of Jumpha, when the villagers accepted him as an ‘outsider’ operating in village fishing grounds, they allowed him to transform the organisation of the fishery into a *kampani*, thus enabling co-operation among those without kinship relations. This process developed thorough negotiations between the migrant Jumpha and the villagers concerning the question of who would co-operate with whom, and share the catch from fishing grounds in front of the village.

The collaboration between villagers and those who identify themselves as outsiders is not a new phenomenon in itself, although representing the fishery as something from the town does open up a new array of positions to the fishers. Re-imagining lakeside relations in terms of town does not undermine, but rather enhances, the possible ways that fishers can redefine their sense of belonging to the village.

By projecting urban concepts on to village fishing grounds, fishers are simultaneously reproducing their rural life. Just as each actor applied urban terms to serve different ends, the new urban terminology produces a multilayered waterscape, against which fishers can foreground or background the urban and the rural against each other, or even ignore the existence of the layering of the one over the other. Just as past labour migrants have mobilised physical distance to manage their relations with and against village authorities,⁶³ the urban metaphors of the fishery allow fishers to navigate the waterscape of power, whilst fishing on village grounds.

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63 Chirwa, ‘Theba is Power’; Van Velsen, ‘Politics of Kinship’.

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